only grown in appeal and practitioners. And, as if echoing the aforementioned historical authors' collective urge to place their monarchs within Islamically ordained spacetime, scholarly works on South Asia's historical periods still elide various political formations – even with vastly different court cultures and socio-cultural geographies – into single monographs principally because of the Islamic confessionalism of these polities' elites.[18] In the face of these countervailing cross-currents, it is difficult – if not close to impossible – to "essay … non-sectarian histories of conquest and conflict," and also cultural transformation.[19]

The ensuing volumes *essay*[20] just such a non-sectarian retelling. They embrace the possibility for new understandings of South and Central Asia's history of the second millennium CE, offered by liberating the point of departure from an inherited urge to write an Islamic dynastic history. Certainly, the chapters that follow focus on the Shansabanis as a kinship-based elite, or *dynasty* (Figure I.3), and they trace their trajectory from unknown origins toward a confederacy of royal lineages exercising prerogatives broadly encompassed within notions of Perso-Islamic kingship – what could be termed a *history*. The work does *not*, however, take it for granted that this kinship-based group were *always* elites, nor that their relationship with Islamic confessionalism was a seamless one. The fissures thereby opened afford the opportunity – thus far too little utilized in the scholarship on Central and South Asia – to examine *which* "Islam" was favored by these *eventual* elites, and why (see esp. Chapters 2–4).

Of course, prior modern works have undertaken close analyses of historical dynasties of the Persianate world, perhaps most relevant being the monographs on the Ghaznavids, considered the predecessors of the Shansabanis in the regions now within modern Afghanistan through India (cf. Chapters 1 and 7). Prior to becoming prized *ghulam*s in the service of the Samanids (*c.* 820–1000 CE), the Ghaznavid dynasty's early founders Alptigin (d. AH 352/963 CE) and his own *ghulam* Sabuktigin (*c.* 940s–999 CE) – father of the famous Mahmud (r. AH 389–421/999–1030 CE) – both came from obscure origins in the vast steppe lands of Turkic and other populations, roughly spanning modern Uzbekistan and Kazakhstan through Mongolia.[21] The broad outlines of Sabuktigin's truly eventful life indicate that his integration into and eventual rise within the Samanid house were undeniably underpinned by a series of dialogical encounters with more than one aspect and type of "Islam."[22] Indeed, his rule on behalf of his Samanid overlords in Zabulistan-Zamindawar (southern Afghanistan; Figures I.1–I.2) and surrounding areas also included the deployment of selective "Islams" in the interests of statecraft (cf. Chapter 3, notes).

But the existing studies on the Ghaznavids, emerging from the last century of scholarship, treat them principally as Perso-Islamic kings who constructed an empire, once extending from Rayy in the center of the Iranian Plateau to Lahore in the Panjab, and possibly beyond (see esp.